

Practice Paper 28 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “Did not trust my face to keep its composure”

1 mark for understanding that the narrator was **emotionally affected** / **on the verge of tears** or **distress**; **1 mark** for explaining that he feared he **could not hide his feelings in public** if he went over to the men.

Sample answer: The phrase tells us that the narrator was **deeply upset** by the new fence going up, and that he was afraid his **face would betray his grief** if he went over and met the workmen — so he chose to stay away rather than be seen losing his composure.

Q2. [2] — “Without quite admitting it to myself”

1 mark — He has been **avoiding** the truth of his decision; **1 mark** — he is in **quiet denial** / not yet ready to face the fact that this will be his **final walk** through the field, even though he has already chosen to take it.

Q3. [2] — “Gave at once, almost gratefully, as though it were still mine”

1 mark for identifying **personification** — the gate is given human feelings of gratitude.

1 mark for explaining that this reflects the narrator’s deep **sense of ownership and familiarity**: even the gate seems to recognise him, suggesting the **bond** between him and his property has not yet been severed in his own mind.

Q4. [2] — Unease with changes

1 mark each for any two of:

- The corner where his old wooden trailer used to rust now has a “square, low, foreign-looking machine”.
- The machine is “painted a cheerful blue” — the colour feels out of place to him.
- It has “stickers on it I could not read” — the equipment is unfamiliar / modern.

- “I did not go closer. I was not yet ready to look at it directly” — he avoids confronting the change.

Q5. [2] — The leaning post

- (a) [1]: It suggests his relationship with the field is **intimate, affectionate, and long-standing** — almost a **friendship**, in which small flaws are **cherished** rather than fixed.
- (b) [1]: The new owner has **no shared history** with the field; he would see the leaning post simply as a defect to be corrected, not as a **memory** worth preserving.

Q6. [3] — Emotional state in the pines (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the narrator is **flooded with memories / overwhelmed by emotion** and **surrendering** to it rather than resisting; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “the year I was born” — the pines mark his entire lifespan, intensifying the emotional weight.
- “hidden in them, sulked in them, and... kissed a girl in them” — the trees are tied to layered memories from childhood and youth.
- “whose name I have very nearly forgotten” — suggests how much time has passed, deepening the sense of loss.
- “I did not go into the pines” — he keeps his distance, suggesting the feeling is almost too strong to confront.
- “stood at their edge for a long time” — the **duration** shows how much the moment matters.
- “let the smell of the resin do whatever it wanted to do to me” — he **yields** to the sensory memory rather than controlling it.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [1] — Respect from the new owner

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- He stood “perhaps ten yards away” — keeping his distance.
- He had his “hands in his pockets” — a non-threatening, unhurried posture.
- He said, “Take your time. There’s no hurry.”
- He spoke “very quietly” / nodded “civily”.

Q8. [2] — What is unexpected

1 mark — The narrator had clearly **braced himself for an awkward, possibly cold encounter** with a younger, dismissive new owner; instead, the man is **gentle, patient, and emotionally aware**.

1 mark — It matters because the new owner reveals he too comes from a **farming family** (“My grandfather farmed up the valley”) and **understands what a last walk feels like** — giving the narrator the **dignity of being understood** at the moment he leaves.

Q9. [1] — “The pines kept their counsel”

1 mark — The phrase **personifies** the pines as wise / discreet figures who hold their thoughts to themselves — they have **witnessed** his memories but say nothing, suggesting **silent companionship** / **dignified silence**.

Q10. [2] — “A kind of pride... quieter than most people imagine”

1 mark — The narrator believes pride does **not have to be loud or boastful**; it can be **private and dignified**.

1 mark — He is **quietly proud** of how he tended the field over the decades, and finds **consolation** in that, even though he is walking away from it for the last time.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, dignified, bittersweet, resigned but proud, quietly moving**. (Reject: **bitter, angry, cheerful** — these miss the tone.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Evidence forecasts have improved

1 mark each for any two of:

- A five-day forecast today is as accurate as a one-day forecast was in the 1980s.
- Satellite coverage is **global**.
- Models are run on **supercomputers**.
- Warnings for hurricanes and heatwaves are issued **days or weeks in advance**.

Q13. [2] — “Human memory is asymmetric”

1 mark — **Asymmetric** means **unequal / one-sided**.

1 mark — In context: people **remember the wrong forecasts vividly** (the downpour at a wedding, the ruined weekend) but **forget the correct forecasts** — so memory is biased **against** the forecaster.

Q14. [2] — Why even a 90% accurate forecast feels suspect

1 mark — The public **retains only the failures** — the ten per cent that went wrong.

1 mark — Because correct forecasts pass by **without comment**, the audience’s overall **impression** of the forecaster is built almost entirely from **memorable mistakes**, leading to unfair distrust.

Q15. [2] — Distorting official language

1 mark each for any two of:

- A “thirty per cent chance of producing localised flooding” becomes a “MEGASTORM” or “BOMB CYCLONE”.
- Capital letters / sensational labels are used to drive attention.
- The language used predicts that storms will “OBLITERATE” the eastern seaboard.
- Dramatic visual graphics (“viral graphic”) replace the careful language of official agencies.

Q16. [2] — Blaming the forecast, not the influencer

1 mark — The public **conflates dramatic social-media content with official forecasting** — they do not distinguish between an exaggerated viral graphic and a careful meteorological prediction.

1 mark — As a result, the **official forecaster is blamed** for failures of accuracy that were never actually theirs, **unfairly damaging public trust**.

Q17. [2] — Probabilistic vs certain language

1 mark — **Probabilistic** language gives the **likelihood / odds** of an event (“a forty per cent chance of rain”), acknowledging **uncertainty**.

1 mark — **Certain** language presents the event as a **definite yes or no** — it will rain, or it will not. The public tends to hear forecasts as **certain** even when they are **probabilistic**, which is why they then judge them unfairly.

Q18. [2] — Confident but wrong

1 mark — Those who got the probability **most wrong** were **most sure** they had understood it correctly — meaning they will **not seek clarification** or rethink their judgement.

1 mark — Confident misunderstanding is **harder to correct** than uncertain misunderstanding, so trust will continue to erode without the public even realising they are interpreting forecasts incorrectly.

Q19. [2] — Improving communication

1 mark each for any two of:

- Rephrasing forecasts in **frequency** terms — e.g. “if today were repeated a hundred times, on forty of those days it would rain.”
- Using **visual aids** — coloured ribbons showing the **range of possible outcomes** rather than a single bold line.
- Testing alternative **vocabulary** and language with members of the public to see what is correctly understood.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “the age of the confident, godlike weatherman... has passed”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **wry / gently ironic, reflective, slightly amused, resigned but accepting**. (Also accept: **measured, thoughtful**. Reject: **bitter, sarcastic, angry**.)

Q21. [2] — Effectiveness of the ending

1 mark — The ending leaves the reader on a note of **cautious optimism / hope**: trust can be rebuilt through **honesty** and **better language**, not lost forever.

1 mark — The **contrast** between “honest” and “useful” (against the earlier “godlike” forecaster) reframes humility as a **strength**; the reader is gently invited to **value openness over false confidence**, giving the article a **positive and persuasive close**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why public trust has fallen (Paragraphs 2–5):

1. People **remember the failed forecasts vividly** but **forget the correct ones**, so memory is biased against the forecaster.
2. Dramatic forecasters / social media exaggerate official predictions to attract attention (e.g. turning a thirty per cent chance into a “MEGASTORM”).
3. When such exaggerated storms fail to arrive, the **public blames the official forecast**, not the influencer.
4. The public confuses **probabilistic language** (a chance of rain) with **certain language** (it will rain), and judges forecasts unfairly when the rain does not come.
5. Most members of the public **misinterpret rainfall probability figures**, and those who get them most wrong are also the most confident in their misreading.

What meteorologists are doing to improve communication (Paragraph 6):

6. They are rephrasing forecasts using **frequency-based language** — e.g. “if today were repeated a hundred times, on forty of those days it would rain.”

7. The rephrased version made listeners **nearly twice as likely** to interpret the forecast correctly and less likely to feel the forecaster had been wrong.
8. Some agencies use **visual aids** such as coloured ribbons that show the **range** of possible outcomes rather than a single bold line.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Public trust in forecasts has fallen because people remember failed predictions vividly while forgetting correct ones. Dramatic broadcasters and social-media accounts exaggerate official warnings, and when their inflated storms never arrive, viewers wrongly blame the meteorologists. Most listeners also mistake stated probabilities for certainties, and the most confused are the most confident. In response, meteorologists have begun rephrasing forecasts as frequencies and using visual ribbons to show ranges of outcomes, which listeners interpret far more accurately.

Length count: 78 words from “Public” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —